

Your move, in five questions

Use this page before games and during practice. The aim is to make a sound decision, one move at a time.

- 1. What changed?** Identify what your opponent just attacked, defended, or uncovered. If you are in check, finding a legal response comes first.
- 2. What is forcing?** Look for checks, captures, and direct threats for both sides. Inspect them first; a move does not become good just because it gives check.
- 3. What are my candidates?** Choose two or three plausible moves. Include a defensive or improving move when there is no convincing tactic.
- 4. What is their best reply?** For each candidate, calculate the strongest reply you can find. Continue until the immediate captures and threats are resolved enough to judge the result.
- 5. What does my move leave behind?** Before playing, check the destination square, your king, and any piece or square that will lose a defender. Ask whether a line opens against your queen or king.

THE LAST LOOK

Picture your intended move on the board. Now pretend it is your opponent's turn: what is their strongest check or capture? This brief change of viewpoint catches many simple mistakes.

Phase	Useful default goal
Opening	Bring pieces into play, contest the center, and secure the king.
Middlegame	Find a target and improve the piece least able to help.
Endgame	Use your king actively and calculate pawn races precisely.

How to use this collection

These are original, concise study notes for players who already know how the pieces move. Read one topic, then apply it on a board.

Guide	What you will practice
01 Opening Principles	Purposeful development, a model opening, and choosing moves when you leave familiar territory.
02 Tactics and Calculation	A repeatable calculation method, common tactical patterns, and two diagram exercises.
03 Middlegame Strategy	Position assessment, piece activity, pawn decisions, and useful exchanges.
04 Endgame Essentials	King activity, the pawn square, opposition, rook activity, and stalemate.
05 Attack, Defense and Checkmates	When an attack is justified, how to defend, and two mating patterns.
06 Training and Game Review	A manageable study routine, a game-review worksheet, and a four-week practice cycle.

Reading the diagrams and moves

White is shown at the bottom in every diagram. Files run a-h from left to right; ranks run 1-8 from bottom to top. K = king, Q = queen, R = rook, B = bishop, N = knight. Pawns have no letter: e4 is a pawn move. Nf3 means knight to f3; exd5 is an e-pawn capture on d5. x = capture, + = check, # = checkmate, O-O = kingside castling, and c8=Q = promotion. An ellipsis, as in 1...Kd7, introduces Black's move.

TURN A TIP INTO A HABIT

Start with Guide 00 and Guide 02. After a game, choose one position and explain what you missed. General principles guide your search; the actual position determines the move.

PRACTICE AND RULES REFERENCES

Interactive tactics, checkmates, and endgames - lichess.org/practice

FIDE Laws of Chess - handbook.fide.com/chapter/e012023